Cup1 Competitor Intelligence Report

Custom-printed cups & food packaging – USA and Canada

5 November 2026

1. Executive summary

Nine competitors were studied across four business models. Together they show how this market is won: **low minimums or low prices pull buyers in, free samples and quote forms capture them, and email, ads and retargeting keep them.**

- **Four models compete for the same café buyer.** They are (A) online custom-print brands (YourBrandCafe, LogoCup, CupPrint, noissue), (B) eco-packaging distributors (Good Start Packaging, KimEcopak), (C) large national distributors (Karat Packaging) and (D) Asian factories selling direct (YOON, and Sowinpak itself).
- **The best financial evidence is Karat Packaging (Nasdaq: KRT).** It had Q1 2026 net sales of $116.9M (+12.9%), and online sales were about 17% of that. Tariffs raised its import costs from 8.6% to 13.8% of sales. The market is growing, but tariffs squeeze margins.
- **The market splits on speed versus price.** Digital printers ship 50–1,000 cups in 10–15 days at $0.38–0.50+ per cup. Factory and overseas programs need 10,000–50,000 cups and 8–16 weeks, at about $0.06–0.15 per cup.
- **Every serious competitor offers free samples** (Good Start, LogoCup, YOON, KimEcopak, noissue). A sample program is the standard way to capture leads.
- **Most US/Canadian competitors run heavy tracking stacks.** They use Google Tag Manager, GA4, Google Ads, the Meta and TikTok pixels, Microsoft Clarity session recording, HubSpot or Klaviyo, and SMS marketing. Visitors are retargeted and put into email flows.
- **Our own supplier sells direct.** Sowinpak's website targets brands worldwide with quote forms, live chat and WhatsApp. Cup1 must add value the factory can't: a delivered US/Canada price, compliance documents, a local point of contact, and inspection.
- **Nobody leads with "compliance documented and delivered at factory price".** The Phase 3 positioning still holds.

2. Competitor map

Competitor	Model	Base	Founded	Min. order (cups)	Lead time	Price signal (12oz)
YourBrandCafe	A – online custom print	Georgia, USA	2008–09	500 (1 case)	~3 weeks	$0.38–0.50 (DW)
LogoCup (BoxUp)	A – digital print, design online	USA	2025	50	~10 days	Not published
CupPrint USA (Huhtamaki group)	A – manufacturer + online quote	Indiana, USA / Ireland	2009	1,000	~15 days	Quote only
noissue	A – packaging platform (outsourced manufacturing)	NZ / global, mainly US	2017	Low (varies)	Varies	Quote only
Good Start Packaging	B – eco distributor + own brand	New Hampshire, USA	2009	50,000 (custom)	14–16 weeks	~$0.11 compostable
KimEcopak	B – eco	Quebec &	n/a	10,000	~8–12 weeks	~$0.10–0.15

Competitor	Model	Base	Founded	Min. order (cups)	Lead time	Price signal (12oz)
	distributor, custom logo program	Alberta, Canada			(sea)	(benchmark)
Karat Packaging (KRT)	C – national distributor/manufacturer	Chino, California	2000 (as Lollicup)	Not published	12–14 weeks custom	Quote only
YOON (YoonPak)	D – Chinese factory/exporter	Wuhan, China	2000 (claimed)	10,000	3–6 weeks production	$0.06–0.08 (claimed)
Sowinpak	D – Chinese/Vietnamese factory, direct	Wenzhou, China + Vietnam + Indonesia	2008	20,000–30,000	~35 days	$0.025–0.18 (listing range)

3. How they work – four business models

A. Online custom-print brands. These sell design-and-print as a service. The customer uploads a logo or designs online, approves a proof, pays, and gets cups in 10–21 days. Margins come from convenience and small runs. Printing is often digital (LogoCup), which makes very low minimums possible. noissue owns no factories: it runs a platform on top of manufacturing partners in the US, Canada, UK, Europe, China, Vietnam and Australia. That is the same asset-light model as Cup1.

B. Eco distributors. These sell many brands of compostable packaging from stock, plus a custom-print program made overseas or by partners. Good Start "does not manufacture products and focuses on sales and marketing" (Business NH, 2020). KimEcopak adds services such as a 6-month fixed price, free storage and scheduled delivery.

C. National distributor/manufacturer. Karat runs 12 US warehouses (Texas, California, New Jersey, Illinois, Washington, Hawaii, South Carolina, Arizona, Florida). It sells to chains and distributors ($92.9M in Q1 2026), online ($19.5M) and through retail ($4.5M). Custom print is an add-on with a 12–14 week lead time on overseas production.

D. Factory-direct exporters. These are Asian factories that sell straight to Western brands through SEO content, Alibaba and trade shows. They have the lowest price and the highest minimums, and the buyer handles import, duties and risk.

Where Cup1 fits: an asset-light model like noissue and Good Start, with factory-direct pricing close to model D, plus the landed price and compliance service that model D does not offer.

4. How the businesses are doing

Competitor	Evidence	Signal
Karat Packaging	Q1 2026 net sales $116.9M (+12.9%); online $19.5M (+9.7%, ~17% of sales); gross margin 35.5% (down from 39.3% because of tariffs). Q2 2026 net sales reported as $136.3M (+9.9%), boosted by IEEPA tariff refunds; FY2026 guidance is low double-digit sales growth; new Orlando distribution center	Growing; tariffs are the main pressure
CupPrint	Part of Huhtamaki since 2018 (majority stake). Claims 20k+ customers, customers in 47 countries, and a US plant in South Bend, Indiana, since 2016	Established, backed by a global packaging group
noissue	$10M Series A (Felix Capital, Nov 2021); 80,000+ customers at that time; 200% growth in North America during the	Funded scale-up; current growth unknown

Competitor	Evidence	Signal
	pandemic. No newer public figures were found	
Good Start Packaging	Certified B Corp (score 90.7); +79% year-to-date growth and 12 staff in Feb 2020; donates 20% of profits	Growing niche player; recent figures not public
YourBrandCafe	15+ years; “thousands” of customers; claims impact on 30,000+ restaurants; added a franchise program (YBC Plus), rewards and a blank-supply arm (YBC Supply)	Mature and diversifying
LogoCup	Launched 2025 by BoxUp; uses sponsored trade-press content	New entrant testing ultra-low minimums
KimEcopak	Warehouses in Quebec and Alberta; US warehouses announced (TX, NV, CA, FL)	Expanding from Canada into the US
YOON / Sowinpak	Claimed clients (YOON: Burger King, Tim Hortons, illy; Sowinpak: “2,000+ brands”) – self-reported	Aggressive export push into North America

Private-company revenues are not public. Figures marked “claims” are the companies’ own statements.

5. What their websites look like

Competitor	Platform	Hero message	Main calls to action	Look and feel
YourBrandCafe	Not inspectable (bot protection)	“Custom Printed Cups, Coffee Sleeves, and More”	Shop products, “Fill Your Cup”, free shipping	Bright e-commerce store, product grid, charity: water badge
LogoCup	Next.js (custom build)	“Make a Statement with Branded Cups”	Shop cups, sample pack, “Get Started with One FREE Cup”	Clean, design-led, inspiration gallery, reviews
CupPrint USA	WordPress + WooCommerce	“Custom Printed Paper Cups USA”	“GET A QUOTE”, design services, design templates	Corporate manufacturer look; “Made in USA, 15-day shipping” in the title
noissue	Next.js + BigCommerce + HubSpot	“Packaging for brands”	Design, samples, my quotes, reorder, call us	Minimal, photography-led, by industry (café, roaster, food service), customer logos
Good Start Packaging	BigCommerce	“American-made packaging. Earth-approved.”	Try free samples, reorder, shop by business type	Busy eco store, food photography, “Instagram approved” gallery, live chat
KimEcopak	Shopify	“Simplify monthly inventories shopping in just 3 simple steps”	Custom logo request, sample request, how to order, franchise quiz	Dense, content-heavy, founder-led, many blog categories
Karat Packaging	Corporate site + separate online store (lollicupstore.com)	“Our Brands”	Custom print inquiry, shop online, contact nearest office	Corporate brand portfolio, investor section
YOON	Not inspectable (bot protection)	Factory-direct pages and US-targeted blog	Free samples, free price list, get a quote, WhatsApp	Factory exporter style with heavy CTAs
Sowinpak	WordPress	“Custom Printed Food Paper Packaging Manufacturer”	Request a quote, catalog, contact	Factory showcase: plants in China, Vietnam and Indonesia, certificates, trade shows

Pattern: buyers expect (1) a clear minimum and lead time in the first screen, (2) a one-click route to samples or a quote, (3) proof such as reviews, client logos, certificates or B Corp status, and (4) reorder or account features.

6. How they gather information from website visitors

These tools were detected in each site's live page code on 5 Nov 2026. Tags loaded later through Google Tag Manager may not all show, so the lists are a minimum.

Competitor	Analytics and ads	Email, SMS and CRM	Behavior and identity	Chat and reviews
Good Start	GTM, GA4, Google Ads, TikTok, LinkedIn, Microsoft Ads	HubSpot, Klaviyo, SMS signals	Microsoft Clarity (session recording)	Live chat, Yotpo reviews
noissue	GTM, Google Ads, Meta, TikTok, LinkedIn, Microsoft Ads, Pinterest	HubSpot	Clarity; Clearbit (identifies the company behind a visit)	Zendesk, WhatsApp, Trustpilot
KimEcopak	GTM, GA4, Google Ads, Meta, LinkedIn	Klaviyo, Omnisend; Privy pop-ups; affiliate app	Hotjar (heatmaps and recordings)	Gorgias chat, Trustpilot and Google reviews
LogoCup	GTM, GA4, Google Ads, Meta, Microsoft Ads	HubSpot	Clarity	On-site reviews
CupPrint USA	GTM (other tags hidden behind it)	Quote-list request	–	Customer testimonials
Karat	Klaviyo on the corporate site; inquiry form (name, email, phone, city, message)	Klaviyo	–	–
Sowinpak	GTM	Quote forms (name, email, phone, country, needs)	–	Tidio chat, WhatsApp

How the data is used:

1. **Capture.** Quote forms, sample requests, account sign-ups, newsletter and discount pop-ups (Privy), and logo uploads collect the email, company, location and order size.
2. **Identify.** HubSpot and Clearbit match a visitor's company even before a form is filled in. LinkedIn Insight shows job titles and companies.
3. **Watch.** Microsoft Clarity and Hotjar record sessions and heatmaps to fix drop-off on quote and checkout pages.
4. **Retarget.** Meta, TikTok, Google, Microsoft, LinkedIn and Pinterest pixels show ads to past visitors.
5. **Nurture.** Klaviyo, HubSpot and Omnisend send automated email (abandoned quote or cart, reorder reminders) and SMS.

7. How they reach clients

Channel	Who uses it (evidence)	Notes for Cup1
Google search ads	Good Start, noissue, LogoCup, KimEcopak (Google Ads tags)	"custom coffee cups" style keywords are competitive; test small budgets
SEO and blog content	KimEcopak (city- and province-level posts), YOON (US buyer guides), YourBrandCafe (branding tips), Good Start (sustainability guides)	The cheapest long-term lead source; target compliance/PFAS and "custom cups Canada" topics
Social and retargeting	Meta, TikTok and Pinterest pixels at noissue, Good Start, KimEcopak, LogoCup; YourBrandCafe on Instagram, TikTok, Pinterest, Facebook and X	Café branding is visual; real cup photos matter
Free sample programs	Good Start, LogoCup ("one free cup"), YOON, KimEcopak, noissue	The standard first step; our Sample Kit fits
Trade press and sponsored content	LogoCup's sponsored article in Fresh Cup; noissue as official cup partner at	Coffee trade media reaches café owners directly

Channel	Who uses it (evidence)	Notes for Cup1
	the MICE coffee expo (Australia)	
Trade shows	Sowinpak (exhibitions on its site); coffee shows such as Coffee Fest and the Specialty Coffee Expo sell exhibitor and sponsor packages	Costly; attend as a visitor first to prospect
Chain and distributor sales teams	Karat (four new chain accounts in its Q2 pipeline); YourBrandCafe's YBC Plus franchise program	Multi-location groups need account management
Referral and affiliate programs	KimEcopak (referral and affiliate partners); YourBrandCafe (rewards)	A cheap growth loop once we have clients
Marketplaces	Sowinpak and other factories on Alibaba; Karat's online store	Cup1 sources there; it is not our sales channel
Email and SMS to customers	Klaviyo, Omnisend and SMS signals on several sites	Reorder reminders drive repeat orders

How competitors find prospects: none of them publishes this. Common practice in B2B packaging is building lists from Google Maps and Yelp, LinkedIn, trade-show attendee lists and B2B data providers, then emailing or calling. Tools like Clearbit and LinkedIn Insight on noissue's site show that website visitors are also turned into named prospects. This is industry practice, not verified for each competitor.

8. Competitor profiles

YourBrandCafe (Georgia, USA) – Founded by brothers Bryan and Craig Warner in 2008–09. Low minimums (one case), free proofs, free shipping, and a franchise program (YBC Plus). It also runs YBC Supply for blank cups and gives $1 per case to charity: water. It blogs and posts on five social networks. Threat: owns the small-café, low-minimum segment.

LogoCup (USA) – Launched in 2025 by BoxUp. Full-color digital printing from 50 cups with a 10-day turnaround, an online designer, and "one free cup" to start. It markets through sponsored content in Fresh Cup. Threat: events and very small cafés; not a 30k+ competitor.

CupPrint USA (South Bend, Indiana; Huhtamaki group) – A manufacturer with US and Irish production. 1,000-cup minimum, 15-day turnaround, FSC-certified cups, free design templates and an in-house design service. Threat: fast US-made custom cups with big-group backing.

noissue (global, mainly US) – An asset-light packaging platform with a $10M Series A and 80,000+ customers (2021). It organizes products by industry, sells cups, coffee bags and takeout packaging, and runs a mature growth stack (Clearbit, HubSpot, multi-channel pixels). Threat: a brand-led, sustainable "one-stop" offer.

Good Start Packaging (Bedford, New Hampshire) – A Certified B Corp (score 90.7) that distributes compostable brands plus its own line. Custom cups have a 50-case minimum and 14–16 week lead time. It offers free samples, reorder, and a 20% profit donation. Threat: eco credibility. Opportunity: its long lead time.

KimEcopak (Quebec and Alberta, Canada) – Founder-led eco distributor with custom cups from 10,000, free 3D mockups, a 6-month fixed price, free storage and scheduled delivery. It is expanding into US warehouses and publishes heavy SEO content. Threat: the closest model to Cup1 in Canada.

Karat Packaging (Chino, California; Nasdaq: KRT) – National distributor and manufacturer with 12 US warehouses. Q1 2026 sales were $116.9M, with online about 17%. Custom print has a 12–14 week lead time and serves chains. Threat: the price and scale benchmark for chains.

YOON (Wuhan, China) – Factory exporter targeting US buyers with comparison articles. Claims $0.06–0.08 per 12oz cup, a 10,000 minimum, free samples, WhatsApp and live chat. Threat: price anchor for buyers who can import themselves.

Sowinpak (Wenzhou, China; plants in Vietnam and Indonesia) – Our Phase 2 supplier also sells direct to brands, with quote forms, a catalog, Tidio chat and WhatsApp. It claims 2,000+ brands. Risk: clients could bypass Cup1 and go to the factory, so Cup1's service layer must be worth paying for.

9. Lessons and implications for Cup1

Opportunities

1. Compete in the **30,000–100,000 cup** range, where digital printers are too expensive and factories are too hard to buy from directly.
2. Lead with **“delivered price + compliance documents”**. No competitor leads with documented FDA/PFAS compliance, and US buyers face state PFAS bans.
3. Beat **Good Start and Karat on lead time** (35 days plus shipping versus 12–16 weeks).
4. Use **Vietnam production** as a tariff advantage, especially for Canada while the China anti-dumping case runs.

Threats

1. **Factory disintermediation.** Sowinpak and YOON sell direct. Protect Cup1 with service (a local contact, landed price, QC, documents), client ownership and, if possible, supplier non-circumvention terms.
2. **Low-minimum convenience.** YourBrandCafe and LogoCup win small cafés. Cup1 should not chase orders under 10,000 cups.
3. **Proof gap.** Competitors show reviews, client logos and B Corp badges. Cup1 has none yet, so its first 3–5 clients should become case studies.

What Cup1 should copy for Phase 4 and Phase 5

- A free sample program (our Sample Kit) and a “delivered quote” form with a logo upload.
- Clear minimums and lead times on the homepage.
- A tracking setup: Google Tag Manager, GA4, Microsoft Clarity (free), the Meta and LinkedIn pixels, and a CRM (HubSpot free tier) with email automation. Add a cookie-consent banner.
- An SEO blog on compliance (PFAS, compostable labeling, tariffs) and city-level “custom cups” pages for the US and Canada.
- Reorder reminders and a referral program once clients exist.

Effect on Phase 3 branding: the findings support the approved positioning (eco + compliant, factory-direct, delivered). Two additions are recommended: show the minimum (from 30,000) and the lead time (about 35 days plus shipping) prominently, and plan a “Request a Sample Kit” call to action alongside “Get a delivered quote”. No change to the name, tagline or visual identity is needed.

10. Method and limits

- Desk research on 5 November 2026: company websites, press releases, trade press and SEC-filed press releases.
- Website technology was detected by inspecting each site’s live page code in a browser. YourBrandCafe and YOON block automated browsers, so they were profiled from their page content only. Tags behind Google Tag Manager may be under-counted.
- Private competitors do not publish revenue. Their figures are self-reported or come from older press articles, and are labeled with dates.
- The Q2 2026 Karat figures come from an AI-generated earnings summary (Quartr) and should be checked against the company’s 10-Q.

11. Sources

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